directorship? What was the social composition of the board of directors? What was their stance vis-à-vis VOC and how did this alter the balance in the board?

As the company was originally promoted by the merchants of Tuticorin it comes as no surprise that they constituted an overwhelming number in the board. After the expansion, vakils and bankers from Tirunelveli/Palayamkottai formed the next biggest contingent. The other new members were from various parts of the presidency. While there were significant shareholders from outside Madras Presidency it is likely that none of them took the qualifying shares; further it might not have been practical to have a director from far-off.

Among the company's directors were many *mittadar*s (landholders), honorary magistrates and bankers.[16] Given the origins of the company, it is not surprising that Vellalars—mostly from the Tirunelveli region and a clutch from Thanjavur (more specifically, the temple town of Sirkazhi)—clearly identifiable by the caste surnames of Pillai and Mudaliar—formed the biggest segment. Four carry the surname of Chettiar—not to be confused with the traditional moneylending and philanthropic community of Nattukkottai Chettiar (Nagarathar), so well known in the academic literature—who were in fact Saiva Chettiar, a small community in the Tirunelveli region with close social and matrimonial ties with Saiva Vellalars.[17] There were also five Brahmins from various sub-castes. One was a Christian Vellalar (M.D. Devadoss Pillai), and three were Muslims. With the dropping of Maya Nadar and the even earlier exit of Anthony Savarimuthu Rodriguez (a Paravar, and as is evident from his name, a Christian), the diversity of the board was dented by the absence of any 'lower' castes. However, with the high bar on entry—100 shares—and the level of economic development in a colonial society the diversity among the directors was not insubstantial.

Unfortunately, beyond their provenance, occupation, and caste we know little about individual directors. In an earlier chapter we outlined the biography of two of the early directors: Pandithurai Thevar and S.V.